The revolutionaries in turn castigated him for his dogmatic adherence to utopian non-violence.

When twenty-four of the revolutionaries were tried in the Lahore Conspiracy Case 1931, they explained their approach to violence on the very first day of their trial by a special tribunal. This was on 5 May 1930 at Poonch House, where the Punjab Civil Secretariat offices are currently located in Lahore. Violence, they declared, was *not* a matter for them. It was up to their oppressors. They were merely reacting to their oppressors. In a four-page petition signed by five of the under-trials, [2] they made it clear that the special tribunal had no jurisdiction even to try them. They stood for a radical change, and colonial rule in India was the very negation of the principles of justice. So, every effort had to be made to bring about its end. This was morally justified because the government of the day was ‘a pack of exploiters’ who were only in control because they wielded the power of the sword against people and had ‘predatory motives’. This government used the language of law and order. Their design, however, was to ignore the law and always to crush all those who opposed them. They forgot that people had inalienable rights. Indeed, if the choice lay with the revolutionaries, they would rather not use any violence at all. The revolutionaries lived by altruistic principles. They were lovers of peace. For the peace to be genuine and permanent, however, it had to be based on justice and equity. It had to be real and effective and could not be artificial and illusory. The government of the day could not impose it at the point of bayonets. Bombs and pistols were a matter of ‘a terrible necessity’ only. Violence for the sake of violence was not what the revolutionaries wanted. However, does the evidence support this thesis? It does if one looks at what Bhagat Singh was indicted for. The fact is that there were only ever two instances of purported violence on his part. One caused no human casualties, while the other did. Both are worthy of consideration.

The first was the throwing of two smoke bombs in the Central Legislative Assembly in Delhi on 8 April 1929. The aim was to prevent the passing of two government bills. The protest would ‘make the deaf hear’. The act was carefully calculated not to injure anyone. In this, Bhagat Singh